That's the spirit, Catra!!!

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/65553391.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Other

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Jeeves & Wooster (TV 1990)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), OC and OC

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), OC - Character, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Idiots in Love, Alternate Universe - Human, Forced Marriage, Getting Together, Crossover

Language:
English

Series:
Part 5 of CATRA AND GREYSKULL

Collections:
SPOP 5th Anniversary Big Bang

Stats:
Published: 2025-05-14 Completed: 2025-06-04 Words: 12,874 Chapters: 4/4

That's the spirit, Catra!!!

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/65553391.

Rating:

Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:

Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:

F/F, F/M, Other

Fandoms:

She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Jeeves & Wooster (TV 1990)

Relationships:

Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), OC and OC

Characters:

Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), OC - Character, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:

Idiots in Love, Alternate Universe - Human, Forced Marriage, Getting Together, Crossover

Language:

English

Series:

Part 5 of CATRA AND GREYSKULL

Collections:

SPOP 5th Anniversary Big Bang

Stats:

Published: 2025-05-14 Completed: 2025-06-04 Words: 12,874
Chapters: 4/4

That's the spirit, Catra!!!

by the_Frank

Notes

It's the height of the jazz age and London is as swinging as it can be, as the roaring twenties roar on.
Adora S. Greyskull, young, rich, sporty, the definition of a loafer and maybe not the most intelligent of the bunch lives her life happy and sorrowless.

But there is always a cloud on the horizon, and mostly that cloud is her Aunt Sharon Weaver, who tries to either marry her off or get her tangled up in a nasty scheme.

And then there is Glimmer. But luckily for Adora, she has an ace up her sleeve. Her trusted valet, her Gentlewomans Gentlewoman, the inimitable Catra to help her out of any sticky situation. Or perhaps I should say "She gets one" becuase this is the story of how the two met.

This is the origin story of CATRA AND GREYSKULL. Please enjoy with a cold drink.

Basically how P.G Wodehouse might have written Catradora.

Part of this years SPOPBIGBANG.

Illustrated by Gloriaaroace

Covertart by MUSTLOVEFROGS.

Proofread and optimized by Bagge.

Chapter 1

That’s the spirit, Catra!

by the Frank

> 

Catra and Adora S. Greyskull

To get you in the mood.

Part 1.

These days, when we are as thick and thin as something that is very thick and thin, it is hard to imagine a life for me without Catra in it. But naturally there was a time pre-catra of course, it just that… those days are not really that fun to talk about, considering the fact that, well, life *with* her is so much better than life *without* her so there isn't anything really especially spiffy to talk about or mention. And yes, I am very well aware of the fact that people keep telling me that I give her a way to long a lease as suitable for a servant but really, she has saved me from so many pickles that the glass industry should be out of work soon! Anyway, life pre-catra. Yes. Not much to say, I suppose. I was young, I was living in London. (I still am, kinda and still do, but you know how it is.) I had a nice and steady-flowing rill of money to make sure I got what I needed to survive. That did include a few weekly shindigs, but annoyingly enough I can't seem to recall half of them (but they had a tendency to end at the old bailey at seven in the morning and a new part of my inventory I had no memory of precuring) and I am not allowed to talk about the rest. Especially that episode at the Princess Club where Glimmer and Mermista had put a fiver on who could stay the longest in a bathtub filled with cold lemonade. There was only one bathtub, you see and it all kinda evolved into a … Well, Glimmer AND Mista have threatened to make me work for the embassy if I spill a word. But I have to say, I did not know you could do *that* with a lemon.

Perhaps I should take a moment to describe what the princess club is. On the other hand, most of you know what a club is, so it might be unnecessary… On the other hand, I have yet to see something similar in America so… Have you been there? I have been there a few times, remarkable place! But they don't seem to have clubs. Well! First of all, to have a club, you need members, and to enter the facilities of the club, you need to be a member. You follow me? There are more than a few clubs in London where you can meet and fraternise with people of… well, your kind, you know. The ones who 'get' you. Even Aunt Sharon is a member of one. It's named Harpers Club, but Catra is convinced it's the harpy's club and that they just misspelled it. Anyway, yes. The

princess club is for influential, educated or rich women in London who wants to be more influential, educated or richer. Our motto is "Gravis est fides mundi quam hominum manus ingerere” but most of us just go there for food, a drink or three and practice a sport. And gossip. That’s why Glimmer is a member. Now where was I? And why is the club important for this story?

...

Ah nevermind! There is quite a bit of an interesting story connected to the very first day Catra was in my service. And there are two significant details in my narrative that led to her being my very own knight in black armor! The whole ordeal started on a Wednesday. I am pretty sure of that, because I had to skip fencing due to having my skirts up in jiffers, which I very rarely do! A gentlewoman always keeps her appointments, so that says a lot about the mood I was in!

First of all, I was getting married. It was not really something I wished for, actually the complete opposite! I am not a woman opposed to marriage, I have been a guest to a good number and I have seen how happy people can get if they meet the right one! Unfortunately, people around me had a tendency to decide who the right one for me was, and not really caring or asking for my opinion… Second of all, I had to give my former maid notice. I do say, I enjoy a good joke as much as everyone else, but nicking a few of my outfits and heading to Brighton with a corporal in the army under the guise of being me is not what I would call a joke, which is what her explanation was when I found her out. She took the opportunity when I was on holiday with a few friends, the only problem was that we also did go to Brighton. So out the door she went. Although Flutterina did look good with long blond hair, that is hardly to be considered a point in her favor! Catra knows her of course and says she has potential to go far…or to Princetown.

Hence, the day before I had sent a wire to the agency for a new example of the London Specimen known as chambermaid, but at

that very moment I had very little of that on my mind. The marriage was forcing its way into my head with the velocity and elegance of a out of control bicycle. My aunt Sharon had been at it again you see. She is the main source of 'this man should be able to make a decent human being out of you, Adora' in my life, and I was at the time engaged to be married to a man called Deller. An absolute bore, if you ask me. A musician by trade, but not one of those fun ones who enjoys a good rag or perhaps a few jolly tunes from the scenes. He believed that every major chord was to be avoided like the plague, and he sure was good at staying healthy. I had once or twice mentioned a few songs, like that one… What was it now… In olden days a glimpse of something was something for something something but now god knows, anything…something. He had but sneered at me with the 'poor Adora'-look plastered on his face. No no, it was all Brahms, and Bartock and that composer… what's his name again… Sch… sch…. Schubert! No not Schubert… Sch…Sch… Chopin? No not Chopin… Sch…Sch… Oh yes! Liszt It was!! All splendid, probably and he got a lot of noise out of my old grand piano but it was not music to drink to. It did give you the impulse to have a drink afterwards however. A big and strong one, to forget the awful mood. Anyway, as we were engaged, we were supposed to make public appearances on the social scene 'to make sure that people believed that there was something inside my empty shell' as Aunt Sharon put it. Now, as you know, I don't mind a good night on the town, especially in the company of Glimmer or Mista, a few other girls, some drinks, a good meal and perhaps a revue and in the morning you woke up with a policeman's cap in your arms and your hat nowhere to be seen. Not that night. We did dine, but after that we went to the Opera to see Parsifal. It was… Um… Well.. It was… It was… German. Yes. That was what it was. Someone shouted, some died, and a lady appeared though the floor, screamed and went back. In the intermission I met up with old Tucker Pucker, and we shared a good laugh until our cavaliers without remorse dragged us back into the salon. Tucker (or Wilhelmina Ratzenberg-Shelby as her christian name is) was also trying her hands at engagement. This was the third one in two years, and from the look on her face, it would soon be followed by

a fourth. She wants a *real* man, she says, but not someone that will rule her life. Someone that people will *think* will rule her life when in fact she is the one in charge. This one apparently didn't get enough hints. I gave her a 'poor sod'-look as I was pushed back into my seat. I can't say it was a better experience, the second act was impossible to understand. It wasn't until Tucker was kind enough to tell me that I fell asleep during the real second act and what I saw was the third, which took place several years later. For once, it was my luck that I don't snore when sleeping in a sitting position.

Once he had dropped me off at my gate I had to get something sturdy under the dress and that before I lost the will to live. So I took a cab down to the club where I spent a few hours with Mista, , Fuma, Tucker (who had ditched *her* cavalier as well) and a bottle of Gin.



It didn’t take long for the discussion to end up being about music. (It started with a discussion whether or not Glimmer could catch an olive in her decolletage from a distance of ten feet, but since we didn’t find any olives we had to try something else.) Tucker wants to sound cultivated, but doesn’t really care about what she listens to, as long as it is the latest. That has given her rather a broad knowledge of contemporary music though. She is

not sure what to do about it, since crosswords are only one third musical questions and she "looks too good to become an academic" in her own words. Glimmer is all dance music, if you can't move your feet to it, there is no point. Mermista wants to appear completely uninterested, but she has the best voice of us all, and it is an official secret that she is the leading woman in the choir at her local parish where she can belch out "Jerusalem" at the top of her lungs as much as she wants. (I have heard her, it is remarkable.) With that in mind, and the bottle of gin involved, I think you can excuse me if I don't give you an excerpt from the conversation, save for one part which is a bit crucial to my further narrative.

"Opera" I said "Is probably all well and good. But does it always have to be so sad? It always ends with the heroine dying violently."

"No really good way to do that with a smile on your face, is it, Greyskull?"

"I didn't mean it like that, Mista! I meant… why can't an opera be jolly and cheerful?"

"That's what music hall is for." Glimmer remarked.

"There is Gilbert and Sullivan" Tucker remarked. I shot her a surprised glance. Gilbert and Sullivan was all the rage at the beginning of the century but hasn't been fashionable since my Uncle Ordacs time at Oxford. Not that I mean that it isn't good. I really enjoy a good G&S, I have seen most of them actually. But for Tucker to know about them…

"Number three, vertical. Times Crossword last week. The highest ranked in a Gilbert & Sullivan piece. General it was."

"Ah. I said. The very model."

"Yeah, something like that."

My mind went to a performance of “The Pirates of Penzance” a few months ago. It was a real delight, but the peace was broken by Glimmer.

“What is the point of them, really? To me, it just sounds like classical stuff. No rhythm. No jive.”

“It’s classical music, Glim. It’s not supposed to be.”

“And you miss the point!” I said. “Sure, it’s not the jolly tunes of the music hall, but it's witty, and funny and… a bit like a farce combined with a fairytale. Like, The pirates, okay? It’s about this boy, named… Frederic. Who has been a pirate's apprentice, right? And not…”

“How are you a pirate's apprentice? What do you do? Hold the gun while someone else fires it?”

“Huh. I….I don’t know. He just is, I suppose? Anyway, he is soon to stop being an apprentice, but then they find out that he is born on a leap year, right? So while HE thinks he’s 23, in reality he’s six! So he has to keep working for them and…”

“THAT. Is plainly. Ridiculous.” Mista.

“I know! And that is the fun about it.”

“Alright, if it is so witty, give us a joke!”

“Well… If a man can't forge his own will, whose will can he forge?”

They stared at me a little, but then they began to snicker. I continued with

“When every blessed thing you hold
Is made of silver, or of gold,

You long for simple pewter.” and “Things are seldom what they seem, Skim milk masquerades as cream.” And so on and so on. I

tried to recall as much as I could, even sang a few songs. At the end, to my delight, they were mostly laughing or smiling. Glimmer even laughed at a few moments even when I had no idea it was supposed to be funny.

When I remarked about that, Mista said "Eh. That's nothing unusual. You, Greyskull, laugh at a joke three times. When you hear it, when you get it explained, and when you understand it. Some of those were just phace 2."

"Now Mista! That was…"

"Besides, your voice is terrible. Let's have another drink before you go into 'Oh better far to live and die'."

I stared at mista, since that one is a staple in 'The Pirates of Pencanze"

"Do YOU know 'the pirates', Mista?"

She looked at the bar and very much not at me.

"NO. DRINKS! NOW!"

(In the end, she joined me and we sang it all.) It was a fun evening, although the last parts of it are a bit dim.

Somehow I did end up back at my place because I woke up by the sound of my own doorbell, still fully dressed (but my hair looked a bit like a haystack). I managed to find my way to the door, and opened it. Behind it stood a dark, youngish chap wearing an impeccable brown suit and a bowler hat, placed on top of a wild mess of hair that yet looked like it was perfectly in order for him. I looked at him. He looked at me. I looked at him again. He was still looking at me. Finally he cleared his throat with a discreet cough and said "I have been sent by the agency. They said you requested a servant. You are Miss Greyskull, are you not? Miss Adora Greyskull?" His voice was low and with a slight rash, not unpleasant. But there was something… I was so taken aback that I could hardly get a sound out of my mouth. I

had asked for a servant, but a maid, not a valet! I mean, not that there is anything wrong with men, far from it! Many of my best friends are men. It's just that… they are MEN. And I don't want them in my apartment. Which is one of the reason marrying Deller would be a bit of a bummer. and like a letter through the mail, the thought about having to be married to Deller came to mind and I froze up even more than before. The chap looked at me, bottom to top. "The name is Catra, miss Greyskull." I was still at loss for words. Finally he said "I see, miss Greyskull." and made his way to the kitchen. Some minutes later he returned with a cup of coffee and a glass of something brownish. "A special blend of my own invention, Miss Greyskull. Many of the ladies I have worked for have found it very refreshing." I took the glass and emptied it in one go. I think I had decided that this whole thing must be a dream, and neither the drink, nor the man was real.

Have you seen the way an electric lightbulb instantly comes to life once you press the switch? The second the mixture hit my intestines I was as clear as a day!

"I say!" I said. I tried to move my head around a little and none of the joints seemed out of place. "I say!" I said again. "You would be hired instantly but… well… you seee… I wanted a …well… and you are a… well, unless you…No that would be absurd… or would it?"

He coughed. "If you are referring to my clothes, miss, it is barely a matter of comfortability. I *am* a woman, just like you asked for. I simply… prefer the freedom of trousers compared to the limits of the skirt."

As I once again looked *her* over, I can't believe I had not seen the woman under all the garments. But now it was impossible to unsee. Her skin was of that slightly brownish shade that either comes from spending a lot of time outside or you have relatives in spain. She looked way too respectable to be one of those hikers, so I suspect the latter. She had this peculiar thing, one eye was

blue and the other yellow. It made her quite mesmerising… ANYWAY! There was nothing wrong with her posture, but I knew not only in my heart but also in my liver and spleen that Aunt Sharon would hate her.

However, there was no time for the agency to send someone else to me before lunch so she had to do, at least for a day. I swallowed the coffee. It was strong and hot and for a second I was out of breath again. Finally I said,

"Catra?"

"Yes, Miss Greyskull?"

"...your room is next to the kitchen. If you don't mind, I would like some lunch.

"Right away, miss Greyskull. "

"Oh, and Catra…

"Yes, Miss Greyskull?"

"Well! Ehrm…… could you perhaps… change to something… more appropriate?"

She gave me a look (a look no servant should ever give their employer. In my mind I said '24 hours. And then she will be gone.') Then she bowed. "Of course miss greyskull." and left the room leaving only a gust of wind behind her. I sipped on the coffee and realized that I had to get re-dressed as well! ! Aunt Sharon was coming over to ask how the visit to the opera went!

In that moment, Catra re-appeared, wearing another impeccable suit, this time a black one. She also had a blue dress with a fresh pair of silk stockings and clean unmentionables accompanying them.

“I believe this would suit you for today's visit, miss Greyskull.” I looked from the dress to her and back. “How did you…”

“Mrs Weaver telephoned the agency to make sure that the replacement was ready in time for lunch, miss. If you don’t mind, I will prepare a tomato soup. I think that would be most suitable for your stomach at this very hour, miss.”

And out she was again, without a sound. How *did* she do that?.

I returned, re-dressed, from my chamber about 2 plus 20 minutes later. I felt the need for another cup of the black aqua vitae before the dragon arrived (I hardly need to introduce Aunt Sharon to you, since this is not my first narrative, but perhaps a short description for a newcomer. She is the kind of woman who could get a wild tiger to become vegetarian with only a few looks.) so I entered the kitchen where I found Catra in the middle of chopping vegetables. She turned to me.

“Yes, what can I help you with miss…Greyskull…” She paused, giving me a look of strong disapproval. Her eyes went to my forehead. “Is it really your intent to wear your hair in that kind of style, miss Greyskull?”

“Why yes!” I said, with some heat. Again, I say, the nerve! Some servants believe that you are a child not a grown woman, who needs constant care! Like I was wearing diapers! I say! I realized that that look and that tone was the waving red flags of the beaches of the south coast! I was too far out to reach land, this woman was a shark! And the suit should have been a clear warning, I should have shown her the door instantly. But that re-booter must have gotten to my head more than I expected. Well, she could prepare lunch, but it was time to set the foot down and show her who wore the stockings in this house! “Is there a problem with it?”

“That hairpoof is not exactly flattering for you, miss Greyskull.”

"Oh! And why indeed not?”

“It shows off your forehead too much, miss. It makes you look like…”

“An idiot?”

“I was going to say a bit childish, miss.”

It is not the first time I have had my hair insulted, but again, *not* by a servant.

“Listen Catra! If you are to be in my service longer than the next day, I want you to keep your mouth shut with your opinions! I wear my hair the way I like, and that is it! And no garlic in the soup.”

“These are onions, miss.”

“GOOD!”

I turned on the spot and marched out. I had shown her!

End of part 1.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Chapter art by MUSTLOVEFROGS.

Part 2.

I know I was supposed to tell Catra off, but for some reason it didn't feel as good as it should have. I have given servants a piece of my mind before, but this time… I felt like I did something wrong. Ah well. It would pass.

Some time later, Catra appeared to announce "Mrs Weaver, miss Greyskull" and the lady entered, wearing her most devilishly red dress. She is a conservative but dresses like something from a heathen nightmare. Although, that may not be a contradiction. Anyway, she didn't bother to wait for me to greet her. She sat down and scrutinized me. And it didn't take long for her to disapprove of what she saw.

"Adora." she said.

"Yes, Aunt Sharon" I said.

"Stop talking."

"Yes, Aunt Sharon."

"What did I just say? Anyway. I just got word from Deller. He told me of your little… embarrassment yesterday."

Dammit! So he had noticed!

"I was not asleep! I was just…enjoying the music."

“Indeed? If you were, mumbling something about ‘can someone please kill that cat’ during an adagio is not really a sign of being aware of your surroundings, is it?”

I had nothing to say about that.

“However. Deller says that he will make an educated and respectable woman out of you.”

“I am educated! I went to Oxford!”

“*As I said*. He will make you *educated*.”

Damn London School of Economics students. They will never forget…

“So you are to go on a little trip over the weekend. There is an open-air concert version of Turandot in Somerset, a concert with Mahler's 6th symphony in Dorset, and a collection of Bach played by three cellos in Winchester cathedral. All during the weekend. He expects you to be ready on friday.”

“Couldn’t they have used four cellos so we could be home faster? They are giving Pinafore at the Savoy.” She gave me an ice cold look (I think. Her glasses were as dark as ever.)

“Do not mention Gilbert and Sullivan to Mr Deller. He abhorrs them.”

By that time in our conversation, Catra had entered with the soup. Aunt Sharon said nothing, but glared at her. Once she had left she said “That thing has to go. She will have nothing but an ignoble influence on you.”

“...You noticed it was a woman?”

“You didn’t? Adora, you reach new depths every day… A passable soup though.”

The rest of the luncheon was in raw silence.

She left, and informed me to be ready on Friday after lunch. Deller would pick me up in his car.

As Catra entered, I let out a sigh. (I know you're not supposed to express that type of emotions for a servant. Nowadays I know that Catra is different but at that time I had no idea why I was so outspoken in her presence)

“Well, Catra. Your engagement with me may be shorter than expected. I am to be married.”

“So I heard, miss Greyskull.”

“Dagnabbit, the man is an absolute ass. Now, I don’t mind music, but I prefer when it has some beat to it, you know?”

“There are a few modern American composers that are inspired by African-american styles of music, miss Greyskull.”

“Well, that’s no comfort! It’s not their works that will be played during the weekend!”

“I am sorry to hear that, miss Greyskull.”

“And I won’t even be in time back home to watch Pinafore, to get it out of… That’s it! Catra, I have it!”

“Indeed, miss?”

“Aunt Sharon said that Deller hated Gilbert & Sullivan! I will wear my best Mabel-inspired outfit, and I will make sure to compare everything we hear to the works of Gilbert!”

“It was Mr Sullivan that was the composer, miss.”

“No matter! Some of what we see must have words in it, won’t it?”

“...It is probable, Miss.”

“That settles it then! I will set my plan to action tomorrow! We will invite mr Deller to dinner and I will play a few numbers from “the pirates of pencanze” Especially some of Mabels songs… That will definitely make him look at me as unmarriable!” Mabel is the character the male lead falls in love with. She is a bit of a whiff, but I kinda like her looks. Catra had listened in silence. Again, she gave me a *look*, but she said nothing and finally she bowed.

“I see miss. I shall prepare a suitable meal.”

And out she went! This was more like it! I suddenly imagined her staying a while longer! That thought filled me with a sudden warmth… Well, no matter! It was time to start practicing!

It took me the better half of the next day, but soon I had my little program ready! It consisted of “Poor Wandering one”,”Leave me not to pine” and “I am the very model” Alright, the last one Is not really especial woman-y but I once learned the words for a bet and it would be a shame not to use it. Anyway, once I was done, I asked Catra to help me with support, and to my surprise she took my place at the piano and sang the parts of the chorus (Although in a slightly rasher voice than usual of course). She was surprisingly good at piano, which I remarked. She bowed again. “Thank you miss. I had the opportunity to serve one of England's most virtuous pianists for a short while. I picked up some bits here and there.”

I did feel it would be a shame that I couldn’t keep her, but I had no time to dwell on that. I had to get dressed.

Once I emerged from my room, dinner was ready on the table, and I was dressed to the nines. I wore the white -with red decorations-dress that Mabel usually wears complete with hat and umbrella. As Deller entered, he was stunned. Hah! Point to Adora!

“Good evening, darling!” I greeted him. “To make up for last time, I have prepared a little soiree for you before we eat. And knowing how much you love the classics, this will definitely please you! Do sit down! I will make myself ready at the piano.”

As I sat down, Catra discreetly offered him a drink. And then I begun. ‘poor wandering one’ is slow, but it has a steady rythm, and it gives one a lot of opportunity to really show your high register! Ah, when I reached the ‘ thine’ in “If such poor love as mine Can help thee find True peace of mind Why, take it, it is thine!” I really flashed my tonsils to the world! Catra did a decent job as the girls chorus, even if she was subdued compared to a whole chorus. (And she didn’t sang the correct lyrics either! It’s ‘take any heart but ours’, not ‘take any heart but hers!” Deller’s full focus was on me, he only sipped on his drink in those spare moments when he realised he had it in his hands! I continued with the slower, but also more grand “Leave me not to pine”. I made sure to look as dramatic as the music demanded, and I sang it loud, slowly and gracefully. And to end it all on a high note, I gave my all in “I am the Very Model.”

(It was a certain thrill to sing it with Catra, the introduction worked really well, and sold me not only as Mabel but also as her father!)

His face became totally blank, and only offered sparse applause as we had finished.

“Weeeell…I said. What do you think?” He smacked his lips a few times, while I removed my bonnet. I say, it was a very thorough training session! If I should feel the need to abstain from something, singing Opera could good and well take it’s place!

“...You…. certainly have a very… natural… and… raw…Soprano voice.”

“Thank you! It means a lot to hear that from an expert! Well, all this singing has made me really peckish! Let’s sit down to dine!”

And sat down we did, to a two-course meal. For starters, we had

The main dish was paprika chicken, a Hungarian recipe that tasted lovely, and then coffee and a little brandy. All the time I made a few remarks now and then about the brilliance of Sullivan's lyrics and how Gilbert could compose such light, yet dramatic tunes. He just mumbled his responses.

After dinner and some coffee, Deller said goodnight and promised to pick me up as promised. I could see that the man had been shaken at his core!

“Well, Catra! I’d say that once again, my brain has made it.”

“Indeed miss?”

“Indeed, indeed, Catra! You may not know this, but I am quite known among my friends for coming up with cunning plots to get out of messes.”

She coughed discreetly.

“I am aware that you have a certain reputation, Miss Greyskull.”

“Oh, you know, do you?”

“Yes. In fact, a few of your former maids are members of the same club as me, miss Greyskull. They have given me vivid accounts of you.”

I was quite sure that was not to be taken as a compliment, but I didn’t care. Let them slander. I know where my brain is!

“Well, at your next meeting then, you can entertain them with my latest success! I will keep this up for the weekend and by Sunday, Deller will have the engagement broken as sure as sugar.”

“Hmm, miss.”

I was not fooled by her even face, that was a hmm of disapproval! Time to set the heel down! Which was not hard, as Mabel I had my heelest shoes.

“Hmm, Catra? Do I sense a deprecatory attitude from you?”

I could tell she was very close to speak her mind but finally she just blinked a few times and bit her tongue.

“Of course not, miss Greyskull. But if I may give you a little word of advice?”

“A little, then.”

“I am not sure that you really understand Mr Deller, miss.”

“I understand him perfectly well, Catra! That is why the plan will go perfectly.”

She bowed. “Yes miss. I will prepare your bag for Friday.”

And she was out.

Friday morning, I had breakfast with Glimmer. My place. She did prefer breakfast at the club, but she had been dying to meet my new maid, and she was not disappointed. As we got a refill of the coffee, Glimmer followed Catra with her eyes as she left us and gave me her verdict.

“Adora. That girl is a complete wench. Unscrupulous, hard as a rock and absolutely disgusting.”

“I know… but she is polite.”

“Barely! And that hair!”

“Yes… I will give her notice as soon as possible.”

Glimmer paused with her tea cup half way to her mouth. “Give her notice? Oh no! You must keep her.”

And then she bit into her fourth scone. (I had remarked to Catra that the breakfast table was a little overcrowded for two, but she only glanced at me and said that it would be sufficient for us. And it was. Dammit.)

I stared at her. “Keep her? Glimmer, you just said that you hated her!”

“Oh no! I do not hate her! I don’t think I really like her, but I don’t hate her. Besides… you need someone like that.”

“I don’t … Glimmer, you of all people? I don’t ‘need’ anything.”

She put a hand on my arm. “Adora. You are strong as an ox and fit like a young bull. And I would bet on you in any type of fight or game. But you could get lost in the backseat of a cab. And you don’t think.”

“Glimmer!”

“Nope. You don’t.” She paused and made a face that said ‘hold on, I am about to say something that sounds implausible. “You do overthink, though.”

I hmpfed and proceeded to tell Glimmer about my plan to get rid of Deller. She bit into her sixt scone and said “See? That is what I mean. Overthinking.”

“Glimmer, nothing can go wrong!”

“Says the one who got stuck in the food elevator at our college…”

“Glimmer, I didn’t know you couldn’t open the hatch from the inside!”

“Adora. Why would that even be necessary? So the food could get out by itself?”

I did not give an answer to that. Glimmer is one of my oldest friends, we went to school together. I love her like a sister, but there are times when I dislike her just like a real sister. She wished me the best but as she left "Mark my words. You will not be rid of Deller that easy. On the other hand, you won't get rid of Catra either so I suppose it evens out. Ta ta, Adora."

"Ta ta, Glimmer!."

Catra had been nothing but the perfect servant for the days until friday, and after lunch I double checked so she didn't do anything strange to my wardrobe. Mabel has a few changes of appearance, and I wanted to catch them all! But everything was in perfect order. I didn't feel confident enough to bring Catra along, and I assured her that I could take care of myself for a few days. Just give me a toothbrush and fresh unmentionables, and I can survive in a forest! I think. Dressed to the tens I was ready when Deller arrived in a rented car. It was a rather large one, with a designated driver. Well, at least that gave us time to talk. As he tried to inform me about Turandot, I did my best to interfolate with comparisons to G&S.

The opera wasn't so bad, but anything performed outdoors on a bright summer's evening is better than the stuffy opera house. Especially when they allow you to bring your own tea!

We spent the night in a nearby hotel (Separate rooms!) and the second day I used the dress from the start of Act II. The ride in the car held a notable difference from yesterday, though. He said nothing about Mahler on the whole ride, and after the concert (a terrible experience. No tea.) he did not lecture me, but asked for my opinions about certain parts. I kept talking, I mean, I can talk G&S all day! But to my immense surprise, instead of going to Bournemouth, the car took us back to London and he left me in my quarters. He told me he had a lot to think about and that he would visit me for lunch, if it was possible. I said of course! I knew what was going to happen, and the sooner the better!

Catra looked nonplussed as I entered. I had not had the opportunity to call her ahead, but for some reason it felt like she was anticipating me arriving home earlier, because a cold dinner was prepared, along with a nice G&T. Life felt good. I let out a please sigh. Catra raised an eyebrow as she removed my empty plate.

"I take it that your trip went well, miss Greyskull?"

"Oh, absolutely, Catra! Deller will return tomorrow at lunch! Without doubt he will announce the breaking of our engagement."

She muttered something.

"What was that, Catra?"

"Oh, I just found a piece of dust on the mantelpiece, that is all, miss."

She looked as neutral as any Switzerland, but I was not having it!

"Oh no! I recognize a 'says you' when I hear it. Now what is it?"

Was there a slight hint of trying to overcome a strong emotion I detected in her face? But she spoke with the same calm voice.

"I am not at liberty to speak my opinion, miss. You made that clear."

Well then! Finally she had understood her place!

"Good! Then make me another drink and then I will retire! Make sure lunch is for only one, because I don't think he will stay and dine!"

She bowed, and the evening went along nicely. In the morning she woke me up with tea and fresh clothes. It was Sunday, and that is my day dedicated to run through the forest on Swift Wind's sturdy back! It hurt me as much as I think it hurt him, but I had to call it off due to my previous appointment. And I promised

myself to use my free Thursday for an extra session with him, as compensation. But a day without exercise is not worth living! So I just took a stroll down to the Princess Club for a short dust with the old punching bag. To my great joy, Mista was there as well, and ready.

“Hullo, Mista! I say, that is a great surprise! What brings you to the boxing ring on a sunday?”

“Have you spent a Saturday evening at a revue with Sea-Hawk? The man sang along to every damn song.”

“Oh. But he has a nice voice.”

“Not. The. Point. He. Is. Annoying.”

No reason to argue. We all know she would die for her husband, but she would only admit it while actually dying.

“Come on, Mista!” I said cheerfully as I put my boxing gloves on, “It is a revue after all. They do have tolerance for a less than refined audience.” This I know from experience. My uncle Berle runs a theatre in Manchester, and he says that the only difference between an audience that watches a Shakespeare play and a revue audience is that for the latter, the theatre is cleaned twice.

“You have seen him dress.” I have. He wears a long blue coat, a bandana and a Cutlass. Mermista is wealthy enough making sure no one dares to call him out on it but she knows people are looking.

“When he gets really swinging, people think he is part of the theatre company!”

“And that is bad?”

“Then they assume that I am his manager or worse… They think that I am also a part of it and wonder why I don’t sing the chorus!”

Ah. Yes. For a woman who uses ‘whatever’ as often as she does, she is remarkably picky with her outfits and to be confused with a ballet girl, even if it is a tribute to her voluptuous figure, would be a bit annoying. She is very quick to point out that she only shows one leg.

I just nodded and we sparred for a while. A few uppercuts gets the old blood running good and gives you a tremendous appetite! But, I declined Mistas offer for dinner. I had my appointment at home awaiting, which I mentioned to her.

“Your plan?” was her response.

“Why, yes?”

“Then it will fail.”

“MISTA!”

“Nope. It will.”

I hmpfed again. But really, what other reply can you give to a comment like that? The victory will be even sweeter when no one believes in you! I returned home to find Catra preparing lunch. It looked suspiciously like it was enough for two, but I honestly knows very little about cooking so I couldn’t say for sure. And since she had a cocktail and some crackers prepared for me (Boxing really makes you nibbing for a bite) I felt no reason to dwelve further into it. Perhaps she preferred to prepare food in advance? I know some people do that.

I sat down, sipping my second cocktail when Catra entered, clearing her throat.

“Behold, fine Lady, the pirate King.” And then a sight for the heavens appeared.


Kae2025
OC BY GP3119 @KAEMANTIS
@MUSTLOVEFROGS ART (C)KAE 2025

Deller was dressed as the pirate king, right from a performance of "The Pirates of Penzance." At that very moment I completely understood Mistas attitude towards her husband, but in a way this was worse. The outfit, with the large belt (complete with pistols) the kilt and the hat was one thing, but the curly wig he wore and the fake moustache, that was way to big for his face, would have made him stand out even on a stage. The lit cigar was another thing, I had no idea he smoked! And to top it off, he held a small Jolly Roger in his hand. I swear, he looked like a panto, an opera and a farce had had an affair and leave the kid with the royal Shakespeare company to raise. As he entered the living room, he posed for a second to show his remarkable profile (Something the pirate king does quite often. That part is however usually played by someone with a bit of pizzass, and Deller had none. He was just dressed as a pirate.) and then he gave sat down at my grand piano, and proceeded to sing the first verse from "Oh! Better far to live and die". It is a very nice number, where the pirate captain (name unknown, but probably not Basil) talks about how jolly life is being a Pirate. I have to give Deller that, he had a passable singing voice, and he managed to get some of the gusto that the song possess out. He ended on a long note, during he left the piano, walked over to me, and then he proceeded to kneel in front of me. I had no idea what to say.

"Adora! The mabel of my heart!" Slightly confusing since Frederic is the love interest for her, but his outfit IS duller…

"My whole life I have had a dreadful secret!" He paused, looked around and whispered, "I was not more than 14, but already I knew that music would be my destiny. I had already fallen in love with the masters. However…" Here he raised his voice a little, "The second I heard Gilbert & Sullivan I was in love! But, alas, my father was a precentor in the perish of Roxbury on the mead, and he approved of none such nonsense! I held my secret deep in my heart, buried so deep that I planned to die without anyone knowing. But you -and your wonderful reasoning on how the music of Mikadon relates to Mahler showed me that there was no shame to bear! I am ready to face the world as my true self with

you by my side! We must get married as soon as possible! But first…”

He sat down at the piano. “We must SING!”

End of part 2

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

The plot is cooking...

Observant readers might notice that the chapter numbers have gone down by one. I have not scrapped anything, I made a miscalculation... next one Is the last.

Part 3.

We sang through the whole act one, him and me altering at the piano, with Catra takin a part here and there, refilling our drinks and bringing us a few things to nibble on. She also brought out my Mabel outfit, which pleased Deller immensely. If you would look at us from the sidelines, you would have seen two very different expressions. Deller looked like he had the best day of his life, like if his horse at the tracks had found a secret passageway to outsmart the other horses and win the race with the others miles behind. Me, on the other hand felt like the oatbags had been empty for days and that the glue factory truck was around the corner. I tried to smile, but as fun as it was to have a duet partner who knew the words and could sing with gusto, it was also obvious that I was stuck in the crabs claws. You see, if you just looked at it from the outside still, there was a lot in our favour! We were soulmates, in the matter that we could talk for hours about G&S (as a bit of foreshadowing, that is what we did for a lot of the time after that) and once he showed he could play major chords he was not half a bad a pianist. However, I did not look at it from the outside, I was very much on the inside trying to get out! I mean, sure. There was some good parts but. A. He was a man. And I still didn't want a husband! And B, even if he enjoyed G&S, he made it clear that he didn't like Jazz at all, and I have to say that I quite fancy it. I tried to mention a little Swing or Blues or Jive here and there, but he made it clear that in our household there would be no such thing! There can be to much of a good thing, if you don't get any of the other good things, if you

follow me. Finally, intermission came during which Catra emerged, coughing in that discreet way that only she can master, and announced that lunch was ready. Damn the woman! She had set the table for two after all! Or, well… Good I suppose! I mean, I did worry a bit about how to explain to Deller why there was no food but still! Such insolence! I felt my inner Aunt Sharon wake up, and that was horrible! So I had more than one glass of wine with the steamed fish. I had a bit of a trouble standing after that, but luckily Deller remembered that he unfortunately had to do a concert with the music of Eric Satie this afternoon, and he had to leave. But he hoped I would join him to see "the Mikado" at the Savoy this very evening. I could only nod. What had started as a reward now felt like an obligation.

The look on Catra's face was inconceivable. I may not use that word right, but at that moment, I had no words. It was she who broke the silence.

"Should I prepare a suitable outfit for the evening, miss Greyskull? I do believe the play in question is a favourite of yours so I will come up with something light blue." There was a slight hint of irony in her words, and I finally lost it.

"If you are going to keep this disapproving attitude towards me, you can leave this instant!"

"Miss Greyskull, I…"

"No! Not another word. This whole day I have felt your smug attitude, your 'I know better than Adora'-look, and this whole lunch - I specifically asked for only *one* plate- … You think you know it all!"

"I would never…"

"You would and you do! All the time! I don't know what is worse, when you tell me you know better or when you just look at me."

"I have not overstepped any of the boundaries you put…" What a nerve! The woman had been giving me high blood pressure since

the start, not to mention how I felt when I looked into her eyes! This had to stop!

"OH YES YOU HAVE! ALL OF THEM! OUT! THIS INSTANT!"

"Very well, miss Greyskull."

"And STOP with that 'Miss Greyskull'. We both know you don't mean it!!!"

I had to stop to catch my breath. She looked a bit sad, but overall, she seemed calm and controlled. Damn it! She couldn't even take a dressing down correctly! Instead she cleared her throat and spoke.

"Well then, *Adora*. Since I am no longer in your service, I will speak my mind freely. I have been in the service of more than one person from the upper class and I know a mountebank when I see one. Mr Deller could pretend all that he wanted that he was a man with the most refined of tastes, in reality he has a passion for comic opera and music hall. The way he dressed was a clear give away, this was not a man who knew how to dress according to his station, but someone who dressed like people do when they are pretending, which is often to be the case in a farce or a musical comedy. Now, I was not entirely sure about his station regarding Gilbert and Sullivan, but he definitely knew about them and found their work favourable. To be honest, your plan would play into his hands all too well. Even if he only enjoyed them half as much."

"You knew this from the start? You can't be serious!"

"The fact that you are going with him to see 'The Mikado' at the Savoy tonight is proof that I, in fact, am, miss Greyskull."

I did not like the smug smile she gave me, but I felt at the same time that it was nothing more than I deserved. And it didn't look so bad when you gave it a thought! I gestured for her to continue. I had to hear this sad tale to its very end.

“So, both of your plans worked a little too well. He had expected a clean slate, someone who he could keep building his castle in the air with, and went for that impression. You wanted to be what he loathed, and turned out as the girl of his dreams. Right now, your chances to escape this marriage is as small as an ice cube's chance to survive in a steel mill in Sheffield.”

I looked her straight in the face. That smug smile, that way she held herself… such confidence, such elegance! And that Brain! I am the first person to admit that I have made a mistake (Albeit maybe not the first to notice.)

“Catra.” I said. “What is the problem with my haircut?”

For just a second, her face relaxed and there was a glimpse of compassion in her eyes.

“It brings attention to your forehead, which for a person with your skull type is less favourable. People with big heads who accentuate them tend to look like… Eggs, miss.”

This was one of those moments, you know? Like when Cæsar stood there, dices in hand ready to throw or when Columbus said "No, just a little further, lads! I am sure india lies ahead!" I knew my next words would change my life.

“...Catra. I have made the biggest mistake ever. Please, I beg you. Come back to my service. Save me from Deller and I will allow you to do what you want with my hair!”

She smiled. “Very well, miss Greyskull. Let me first start with your dinner and I will probably have a solution ready by the dessert.”

Dinner came, so did dessert. And coffee. It was strong and black, just like my future. I never imagined feeling dread before a performance of G&S but dread I felt. I was fully prepared to pour down the coffee in one go and say that I had to stay home due to a sore throat. But Catra served me such a small cup that I barely felt the sting when I did. I had to ask for another, then a third. Nothing. Barely a few hiccups, but that is not a reason for a

Greyskull to cancel an appointment! Dammit all, Catra or not, I would face the Mikado like a Greyskull! For as long as I was a Greyskull, the honor of Greyskulls must be kept! The honor of Deller didn't really sound as grand, it was more like a good plumber promising "by the honor of Deller, this sink will never leak." And while that is a good advertisement, I can't say that it sounds especially honorific. Even though I really hope the sink doesn't leak. Right, so. After the fourth cup to no avail, I said "Well, Catra?"

"Yes, Miss Greyskull?"

"Do you have any solution? Your place with me depends on it."

"There are a few possibilities, miss."

"And they are?"

"...I suggest that it is better if you don't know everything."

"You don't have a solution, do you?"

She coughed again, slightly aggressive. Then she said: "Miss Greyskull. For my plan to work, you need to act completely surprised when the wheels begin to move. Also," she added, "you might want to be able to deny any knowledge about certain… things… when your Aunt inevitably finds out."

Damn it! I had forgotten about her in all the commotion!

"My god, you are right! She will rip my skin off and wear it as a frock when she finds out."

"Most probable, miss. She seems like the type who deals with the darker powers on a regular basis." For a brief second, there was a real passion in her otherwise stiff face. She did *not* like my aunt.

"Catra…" I said, with a slight disapproval. She can't speak her mind like that if she is to stay long in my service, but… She isn't wrong.

I can without doubt say that this was the longest performance of the Mikado I have ever seen. If you only looked at the watch, it tried to convince you that it had only been a few hours. I was surprised that it was not the next morning as we left the theatre. I have never felt more connected in spirit with Nanki-Poo and his struggles in "And have I wandered for a month." The twists and turns with Yum-Yum having to marry Ko-ko didn't make me laugh as it usually did. Instead I felt sympathy for the young lady. And Deller definitely felt like a Ko-Ko. Well, I had to keep up appearances, but it was not a happy Adora who went to get a small brandy in the intermission. I did what I could, and I mean, the songs are witty and it's very much all fun and games and all that Jazz. But knowing that the man next to me who watched it all with glittering eyes and a smile similar to that of a seven year old who just got a puppy made me sick. Considering I was the puppy, I fully supported the cause I read about the other day who said that you should avoid giving pets to children. And the rest of the week followed a similar pattern! I had no idea that there were so many companies giving Gilbert & Sullivan through the lengths and breaths of england! I wish that at least one of them had held their breath! I don't know what was worse, the face that I couldn't fully enjoy what used to be one of my biggest sources of entertainment, or the fact that I had to cancel all my sports appointments! There is no time for either tennis, Polo or Rugby when you have to take the next train to Swansea, Blackpool or Newcastle on tyne. The only sport I could pursue was running, because the theaters were never close to the stations and Deller was too cheap to call for a cab. And he refused to let me pay. I suppose that is noble of him, and I am an excellent runner. But I prefer not to run in a frock and high heels. It damages my knees.

Catra was not especially encouraging, but she made sure that I looked my best for every opportunity, and there was always something strong waiting for me when I returned. I say not encouraging, but again, since then I have learned her methods of operation. Not a word until things have reached their full development which is annoying as a piece of corn stuck between

your right side molars. So I felt quite desolated as the days passed. Came Wednesday evening, or rather Thursday morning, because the Cornish riviera express was running late. But Catra was still up, and she greeted me with coffee and "Mrs Shadow Weaver is here to see you." Her words shocked me so much that I had to drink two cups before I could even answer her.

"Still? What time is it?"

"1.30 in the morning, miss. She has been here since seven p.m."

"By jove!"

"Yes miss. It has been an interesting evening. I suggested she should return to her lair and come back in time for her morning blood but she declined."

The slight edge to her tone told me that Catra probably wanted to politely tell her to go somewhere else, a place that was slightly warmer. I got to say, I know what I feel for Aunt Sharon, but that Catra, who at least managed to keep her lips stiff enough almost all the time, would be shaken enough to sound slightly bitter surprised me!

The surprise was gone as I entered and greeted Aunt Sharon.

"Hullo, Aunt Sharon. Fancy me…"

"Spare me the imbecilities. You are late."

"The train was…"

"I am aware, and this whole debacle could have been avoided if you had just tried to be… passable! But instead you have gone and corrupted a man that was predestined to be third chair in the musical academy! If this had gone as it should, the two of you would have listened to a quartet in Hammersmith and been home by now!"

"Yes, well… Deller insisted."

“I know. Your condition is apparently contagious because you have managed to make Deller a big a fool as you.” She paused, and added with a sigh. “But I suppose a fool is a suitable husband for *you*. And he is a rich fool, and that helps a lot”

“Aunt Sharon! That is…”

“Just the truth. And by the way, this… servant of yours… Catra. I am glad that you will enter wedlock soon enough because she is the type of woman we used to describe at school at a total tart. And she will only cause trouble for me.”

“...She is my servant.”

“And *you* cause me trouble, and she will make sure that you cause me even *more* trouble. I know the type. It is exactly the same type of woman that made your Uncle Stephen lose his mind.”

Uncle Stephen is one of Auntie's big disappointments. She had hopes of inherit him, but at 53 he fell in love with his cook and moved to Bristol to open a hotel. The last I heard he had three kids and was doing splendidly. Not from Aunt Sharon's point of view, but from *that* point of view, very little was.

“Aunt Sharon! I am not going to move to *Bristol*.”

“Of course not. You couldn’t handle a business even at gunpoint. It’s the principle I am talking about. She is the same kind. Way too frivolous and wild minded. I see nothing but disaster in your future if you keep her. But then again, that is your future anyway, so I suppose it might make little difference. But Mark my words!" She paused. I swallowed. She glanced at her watch. "Now, I need to be going. Some of us have places to be in the morning. Good Night Adora. I expect a wedding invitation at the end of the month.”

And she was gone. Catra entered with a brandy.

“A little night cap, miss. I had the feeling you might need it after Mrs Shadow.”

“Thanks Catra… And it’s *Sharon* Weaver…”

“If you say so, miss Greyskull.”

End of part 3

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As sure as the sun raises, two days later came Friday. The plans were as promising as the weather in November. We were going to this outback little theatre in Chiswick where a traveling company was doing *The grand duke* . It is the last Opera by G&S and at that moment, I was thoroughly grateful they had ended their companionship as enemies. I am all for peace and fraternity, but at that time, hade someone said "forgotten masterpiece by G&S I *would* have kicked them. *The grand duke* may not be well-known, and to be honest, I have only seen it once. And at the same time as I loathed the idea of Opera, I welcomed it like a breeze in the desert, because I felt like I had enough of *Mikado* and was close to hurling if I ever heard "*The very model*" again. This time however, Catra found time in her daily endeavours to encourage me, which had a very intense impact on me... Anyway! This is what she said:

"Patience, miss Greyskull. Things will start moving soon." But even if I felt... something, my responce was to hmpf, which I had been doing an awful lot lately, now that I think about it, but that was just how upset I was!. (In hindsight, I should have known better. This is a sure sign that Catras plan is working exactly as she has planned, but at the time I didn't know.)

The evening ended surprisingly spiffy. The play was not at all unassuming, and while there wasn't any real bangers, there were more than a few pleasing tunes, like one that went… Ehm… Oh yes, Ding, ding dong, ding dong, dong! Ding, ding dong, ding dong, dong! something something action. And the female lead was as gay and joyful as you could expect. But at the same time I have to admit that it was not the most professional staging I have seen, and I *have* seen more village soirees and 'revues' put up by local perishes than the ordinary gentelywoman! …Friends falling in

love with Essex or northern Squiers tend to give you that experience. You would be surprised how easy it seems to be a fella with a large estate and a wish for a london girl to fill up the family coffins. And once they are installed, they invite me. And there is always that Village fête, with me throwing balls at coconuts and drinking bleak tea while I try to get out of the next mess Glimmer has put me into. Now where was I… oh yes, soirees! The worst I have seen was a middle-school group trying to do Christie's "*the mousetrap*". No decor, and the villain had a tendency to always enter the stage too early.

These fellas had a complete stage, but one could see that the costumes had been mended rather hastily and the orchestra consisted of three people. A cello, a trombone and a girl playing banjo. But there was nothing wrong with their enthusiasm, I give them that. And Deller eyes where plastered on the stage the whole time. HE knew all the songs, of course, and seemed to take offence that I didn't. Oh, and there was one of the choir girls that struck me as someone I should know. But no matter how much I searched the dwindling of the old greyskull brain, the name escaped me. Until she had one solo line, and it all came back, with the raspiest voice in the world! It was Lord Wilkinghamshires daughter Anne, that had run away from home two years earlier to follow her dream of being an actor. As you may imagine, she had no talent for the craft at all, and she could not sing for a penny. But she had nice legs and quite the pot of money so I was not surprised that a company desperate enough took her in so they could eat a hot meal at least once a day! And her legs was *really* nice, so she had definitely a place in the ballet. (At the time I had no idea why I always noticed the ladies legs.) Well, once the final curtain had fallen, Deller had to personally thank the director for a 'sublime experience'. It does sound like a hidden jibe but I am afraid he was serious… Anyway, with the combined funds of me, Deller and Anne, we took the whole theatre company out for a meal at the pub close by. Sure, it isn't Catra's cooking, but I sure don't mind some nice bangers and mash from time to time!

Well, anyway. It was quite the whammy evening all in all. Deller and the troupe had a few common acquaintances and I had a nice

time chatting cricket with a few of the leading ladies. It is astonishing how sports bring people together. There was a piano in the room, and it didn't take long for Deller to be persuaded to sit down at it. And more than once did he invite Anne Wilkinghamshire to join him in a chorus. She sang like a bow to a saw, but if that makes you happy, then by all means, saw through the bow! Just don't expect me to listen without a cocktail! Or a beer in this case, of which there was quite a lot. The evening ended on a rather happy note, we all sang... something... as we walked through the streets back to the hotel (Or the underground, in my case.)

In the pre-milkman hours I returned to the old lair, and it took at least two of Catras specials to get the old head back on! The day after was , not suprisingly, a Saturday, and I usually have a late breakfast on those occasions, meaning that I could not have Deller visit my apartment earlier than after One o'clock. And yes, he was coming. He wanted to have an 'honest talk to me'. Interesting how people never can wait until after breakfast to have those! Would some H&E make them less honest? He sat down, declined my offer of sharing my eggs, but a cup of coffee was acceptable. Then he looked at every part of the room save for my face. Ah. The old 'I have something important to say but don't really want to because it will probably hurt you and please don't hit me with the umbrella'-look. But finally, after his third cup (discreetly refilled by Catra. I have no idea how she does that, but my cup was filled as well!)

"Adora" he said. You see, as people pre-engagement, we were on a first name basis. I used his first name as well, and would do so even now but… I just can't recall what his name was. It wasn't especially interesting, to say the least. "I have had an epiphany!"

"I am sorry to hear that." I said. "Do you want an aspirin?"

"I don't need no medication! I have seen the light with your help! I know now where my destiny lies! With the (Here he mentioned

the name of the theatre company which I also can no longer recall, but it was one of those names that sounds like 100.000 pounds and it worth a penny.)! I will join them as their new kapellmeister!”

"Oh." I said.

“And I could never have done it without your encouragement! You have made me see Gilbert & Sullivan in a new light! I used to love them before, a forbidden love! But with your remarks, i Understood their brilliance, their elegance, their papaw! I will now live my life as it was meant to be, as a true... disciple.”

“That is splendid!” I said, not sure where this was going to end.

“However… I… Ehrm… I wanted for you to travel with us, of course. Being my muse and all but… you see… em… It’s like this… Anne and me… I mean… you have a really nice natural voice but hers… It’s a force of nature! Untamed. And I… will be the man to tame it! I will make her famous! So…um…if it’s not much to ask, can we break the engagement?”

Well.

I think I said ‘of course’ and I didn’t recover from the shock until he was well on his way, and Catra had entered with a small calvados.

“I take it that Mr. Deller is out of your life, Miss Greyskull?”

“He is, thank heavens!” I know that Calvados are to be sipped slowly, so I did. It didn’t calm my nerves though so I emptied the rest in one go. Catra quickly served me another, but I knew what I really needed. I felt the need for a parlour scene, because it was obvious that this somehow *was* Catras doing, even if I couldn’t see how. “Alright, Catra. Spill the beans. How did you do it?”

Catra looked at me, face as carved in stone as always but with a sharp glimpse of pride in her eyes.

“Well, miss. I understood that a man, living his life knowing he was a mountebank would jump at the opportunity to ‘be himself’. And there is a certain kind of theatre company that always requires fresh blood, and doesn't always ask for credentials, save for being alive and able to talk without stuttering too much. To find a suitable theatre company, that would notice mr. Dellers talent and would jump at the opportunity to hire him, was easy enough. Actually, I didn’t even have to find one of the more desperate ones, thanks you, miss Greyskull.”

“Me? What did I do right?”

“Well, miss. You had done one thing thoroughly, you had softened him up so much that he was in the state aquin to one of a newly saved."

"Ah!" I said. "Like when Pinker Stinker decided to get sober and talked about alcohol as the devils work, completely forgetting how he had been on a pub crawl last week?"

"Indeed miss. And as you correctly observe, those people always tend to overdo it. So once one of those companies came to London, I only had to book tickets and… perhaps send a five pound note to the clerk to make sure they would go out for drinks afterwards. But even there, you helped. And it all went the way I expected, more or less.“

“Did you know about Anne?” Catra coughed discreetly.

“I did not know about Lady Wilkinghamshires presence when I booked your tickets, miss. But as soon as I got the news I made sure to let her know that mr Deller was an excellent accompanist. I happen to know that she has suffered in the past from pianists being… a little too honest with her about her voice, but Deller seemed to be the type to not understand that.”

“How could that be? She sings like a steam engine!”

Catra slightly raised one eyebrow. “He did say that your voice was rich and raw natural, didn’t he, miss Greyskull?”

At the time I had been convinced that he was just being polite but when I reminisced about it now… Darn it, the man had no taste!

“How do you know her, anyway? You have worked for her?”

“No, but me and her chambermaid turned dresser are old friends from school, miss. She used to stuff baby carrots in her ears after the evening meals when the lady was practicing.”

“Ah.”

“There you have it all, miss. I hope that I have acted to your satisfaction?”

“That and beyond!” I said! “Catra! Get a brush and comb my hair!”

She bowed. “With pleasure. Oh, one thing, miss. Perhaps we should make a visit to the countryside for a few weeks? Mrs Shadow Weaver will probably hear about this development soon and…”

I didn’t need more encouragement! (Also, in all my gratitude, I forgot to correct her.) I had Glimmer on the line only two minutes later and we had managed to get her permission to stay at her cottage in Essex for a while. There was no village fete coming up, which pleased me greatly! Before we hung up after Glimmers “Come right away! I am dying to talk to someone who understands clothes!” she paused briefly and added: “So, Adora… Is Catra coming with you?”

“As a matter of fact, she is.”

“Good. I look forward to hearing more from the two of you in the future..”

And that was that.

Oh, perhaps just a little footnote. It was around six months later, when Aunt Sharon had cooled down, and Catra had helped me and Mermista out of a few perils of which one I am forbidden to speak about ever again (but I had *no* idea you could do *that as well* with a lemon), and we were back at the old lair. Things were finally calming down and I was sitting on the sofa with a collection of Father Browns and a small brandy. Catra was making preparations for the next day and had been refilling through my wardrobe with freshly washed dresses. Save for a slight drip of persp. on her forehead, it all looked so easy, like she was a ship sailing to Rio. Her blue and yellow eye shone warmly in the afternoon sun and her suit was as impeccable and well-fitting as always. It was not until she asked "Is there a problem, Miss Greyskull?" that I realised that I had been re-reading the same page five times now. Instead of concentrating on Father Brown solving the mystery of the ghost of Gideon Wise, my mind had been busy looking at Catra.

In fact, I had been looking quite a lot at Catra recently. In a way that didn't feel appropriate as a mistress to her servant. This feeling had been growing, and as the brandy rose in me (I emptied it in one go as she asked,) I rose with it.

"Catra." I said. "I am afraid you can't stay in my service after all."

"Oh." For a brief second a shadow of disappointment ran over her face. "Have I caused you some distress?"

"Oh! Oh no. No no. " Yes. A whole lot. I was in the grasp of opposite feelings and I didn't know which step to take.

"You see… Catra. I… I am a woman."

For a second it felt like she was at loss of words. Huh. That was a first.

"Indeed you are, miss greyskull."

“Yes. I am aware. And a woman with feelings, Catra.”

“So you are, miss Greyskull.”

“And… a few of these feelings… concerns you.”

“Oh. In what way, miss Greyskull?”

We had moved inch by inch closer and now I stood face to face (Well, I was looking down at her, but you get the idea.) Her face was as motionless as usual but there was a certain… glow in her eyes. It was hypnotising. I had to swallow a few times to regain the ability to speak.

“I… I enjoy your company. A bit too much perhaps.”

She looked at me with her face unchanged, but neither of us moved away from the other.

“I see.”

“And… I have a tendency to keep my eyes on yours for maybe a tad bit too long.”

This time I noticed a slight twitch in her lip. A hint of a smile.

“So I have noticed…Miss Greyskull”

“And… That time you said…my name… I…”

“Yeeees…miss Greyskull…?”

“I felt… something that I probably… shouldn’t feel…”

Another inch and now we stood fabric to fabric. Oh how I wished I could just… Catra cleared her throat in her usual discreet way but there was a little undertone of…warmth.

“I agree that it is a highly unprofessional stance. However, miss Greyskull…” here she brushed away an invisible piece of dust from my dress before she looked at me again. Now her eyes were

almost sparkling, "I have to admit that I feel a bit more *loyal* to you than other employers. In fact, I see it as part of my payment, a little bonus a natural so to speak… I don't mind, if you don't mind…"

"...I don't mind…"

"What else do you don't mind… *Adora…* "

Um. Yes. I feel that this is a good place to end my narrative. I did not give her notice, as you probably know. Instead, My legs started to shake, until she gently took my hands and gave them a light kiss. Then, with a firm hand she removed my jacket. And then. well…Um… You see… Now, we… Yes. *I say!"*

And nothing more needed to be said.

Chapter End Notes

> And that's all folks! Thanks for reading! Huge thanks to Tippenfunkaport for hosting this glamorous event! Enormous thanks to Bagge for proofreading.
>
> Catra and Greyskull WILL return.
>
> Someday.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!